

# Viva Voce

## Student Guidance

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CM4609 · Individual Research Project

Commencing 21st April 2026

# WHAT IS THE VIVA VOCE?

*The Viva Voce is your opportunity to defend and demonstrate your research in person before a panel of independent examiners.*



## Duration

1 Hour Total



## Format

In Person  
20 min Presentation  
+ 15–20 min Q&A



## Assessment

100% of Module Grade  
(Part of overall)

# THE EXAMINATION PANEL

## Who Will Be in the Room?

- Independent Examiner — faculty members not directly involved in your Project
- Your Project Supervisor — Present as an examiner, followed by the independent examiner
- A Chairperson — to manage the session

⚠ *The panel's role is to rigorously assess your depth of understanding.*

## What They Are Looking For

### Research ownership

Can you speak to every decision made in your project?

### Critical depth

Do you understand limitations and alternatives?

### Technical mastery

Can you explain the AI/DS methods you used?

### Ethical awareness

Did you consider SPER issues throughout?

# PROFESSIONAL CONDUCT & ATTIRE

**Dress and behave as you would for a professional job interview.**



## Formal Attire

Smart professional dress is expected — shirts, dress, or equivalent business attire. First impressions matter.



## Punctuality

Arrive at least 10 minutes early. Late arrival may delay your slot. Know the exact classroom and time in advance.



## Stand to Present

Be prepared to stand throughout your presentation. Some examiners prefer this; remain standing unless invited to sit.



## No Reading from Notes

Do not read from slides or notes. Maintain eye contact. Speak to the panel, not the screen.



## Composure & Respect

Stay calm under pressure. Address examiners professionally. If you don't know, say so honestly.



## Tech Readiness

Test all materials beforehand. Have your slides open and ready. Do not rely on an internet connection.

# PRESENTATION STRUCTURE & TIMING (20 MINUTES)

|                              |                      |                         |                          |                         |                             |                    |
|------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------|
| ~2 min                       | ~2 min               | ~3 min                  | ~5 min                   | ~4 min                  | ~2 min                      | 15–20m             |
| Introduction<br>& Motivation | Literature<br>Review | Methodology<br>& Design | Implementation<br>& Demo | Results<br>& Evaluation | Conclusion &<br>Future Work | Questions<br>(Q&A) |

💡 Aim for 12–16 slides. That's approximately 1–1.5 minutes per slide. Practice until you can hit 20 minutes consistently.

| Section                   | Key Content to Cover                                                                 | Time      |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Introduction & Background | Research problem, motivation, significance, research question/objectives             | ~2 min    |
| Literature Review         | Key related work, identified gap, how your project addresses it                      | ~2 min    |
| Methodology & Design      | Research approach, system architecture, justification of tools and algorithms chosen | ~3 min    |
| Implementation & Demo     | Live or recorded demo of your working prototype, key technical highlights            | ~5 min    |
| Results & Evaluation      | Metrics, benchmarking, statistical validation, interpretation of findings            | ~4 min    |
| Conclusion & Future Work  | Summary of contributions, limitations, ethical reflections, future directions        | ~2 min    |
| Q&A                       | Listen carefully, answer honestly, acknowledge what you don't know                   | 15–20 min |

# PREPARING FOR THE Q&A

## Common Examiner Questions

Q: Why did you choose this particular algorithm/approach?

Q: What would you do differently if you started again?

Q: How did you validate your results?

Q: What are the limitations of your solution?

Q: How does your work contribute beyond existing solutions?

Q: What are the ethical implications of your research?

Q: How scalable is your solution to real-world conditions?

### Listen Fully

Do not interrupt. Let the examiner finish before you respond.



### Pause Before Answering

A brief pause shows you are thinking. It is not a sign of weakness.



### Be Precise

Give focused, specific answers. Avoid vague or circular explanations.



### Be Honest

"I don't know, but I would investigate X" is a strong answer.



### Relate Back

Connect answers back to your research objectives and findings.

# EFFECTIVE PRESENTATION DELIVERY

## ✓ DO

- ✓ Practice your presentation multiple times
- ✓ Know your own work inside and out
- ✓ Use clear, confident, projected voice
- ✓ Make eye contact with all examiners
- ✓ Point to slides — use gestures purposefully
- ✓ Keep slides visual — minimal text
- ✓ Time yourself to finish within 20 minutes
- ✓ Bring water — keep yourself composed

## ✗ DON'T

- ✗ Read directly from slides or chits/notesbooks
- ✗ Exceed your allocated 20 minutes
- ✗ Use jargon without being able to define it
- ✗ Apologise excessively for minor issues
- ✗ Argue confrontationally with an examiner
- ✗ Overload slides with dense text or tiny fonts
- ✗ Rely solely on your supervisor's feedback
- ✗ Leave your demo to chance — always test first

# SLIDE DESIGN PRINCIPLES

*Your slides are a visual aid — not a script. Design them to support what you say, not replace it.*

**01**

## One Idea Per Slide

Each slide should convey a single, clear message. If you need to scroll or speak for more than 90 seconds, split it.

**02**

## Minimal Text

Use short headlines and keywords. Maximum 5–6 lines of text. Your voice carries the detail.

**03**

## Visuals Over Words

Diagrams, architecture charts, results graphs, and screenshots are far more impactful than paragraphs.

**04**

## Consistent Formatting

Use a single font, consistent colours, and uniform slide layout. Visual inconsistency signals lack of care.

**05**

## Highlight Your Findings

Dedicate at least 2–3 slides to your results. These are the heart of the viva — give them prominence.

**06**

## 12–16 Slides Maximum

Fewer slides done well. Allocate ~1–1.5 minutes per slide. Practice until the pacing feels natural.

# ON THE DAY — CHECKLIST

## The Night Before

Review your entire presentation, know every slide

Prepare concise answers to likely Q&A questions

Charge your laptop / confirm your equipment

Lay out your formal attire in advance

Set multiple alarms — do not be late

## On Arrival

Arrive 10+ minutes early

Find the room early— do not rely on campus lifts on the day

Open your slides and test AV equipment

Silence all devices

Breathe — compose yourself before entering

## During the Viva

Stand to present unless invited to sit

Speak clearly and at a measured pace

Engage all panel members with eye contact

Keep within your 20-minute limit

In Q&A: listen fully, pause, then answer honestly

# ETHICS, REFLECTION & THE RESEARCH PAPER

## SPER — Be Ready to Discuss

### Social · Professional · Ethical · Legal & Security

Examiners will probe your awareness of how your research impacts people, data privacy, algorithmic bias, and professional responsibility. Know your SPER statement cold.

## Critical Reflection

Examiners value honesty about what went wrong. Frame challenges as learning. Show you understand why a limitation exists and how you might resolve it in future work.

## Your Research Paper

**Must be:**

Based on your original completed work — NOT a review paper

**Format:**

Standard academic journal/conference paper structure

**Sections:**

Abstract, Introduction, Related Work, Methodology, Results, Discussion, Conclusion

**Submission:**

Week 24 just after the Final Project Report

**In the Viva:**

Expect questions on your paper's contribution and novelty

**Key reminder:**

The paper must reflect completed, implemented, and evaluated work

# WHAT YOU WILL BE GRADED ON

*Six criteria are assessed across your Report, Presentations, and Viva — each carries equal weight.*

1

## **Problem Definition, Lit Review & Methodology**

Clear gap, justified research questions, comprehensive and critical literature review, ethical/legal/security coverage

2

## **System Design & Data / Environment Prep**

Justification of approach, dataset or simulation quality, experimental setup, choice of tools

3

## **Implementation & Technical Execution**

Code quality, AI/DS techniques applied correctly, integration, correctness, efficiency

4

## **Evaluation & Analysis**

Appropriate metrics, benchmarking, statistical validation, thorough interpretation of results

5

## **Documentation & Reflection**

Quality of thesis/report, structure, depth of reflection on challenges and lessons learned

6

## **Presentation & Viva**

Clarity, confidence, demo quality, ability to answer questions accurately and under pressure

Grade A → 50% subgrades A, 75% B+ | Attendance at Viva is mandatory — non-attendance = NS

# Key Dates & Final Reminders

|                |                                                                            |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3 April 2026   | IRP Final Submission — Project Report, Source Code & Research Paper (1 PM) |
| 21 April 2026+ | Viva Voce Examinations commence — exact slot communicated by module team   |
| Your slot      | 1 Hour Total · 20 min Presentation + 15–20 min Q&A + Demo                  |

## FINAL REMINDERS

- Your viva is a scholarly conversation — approach it with confidence
- Own your work entirely — every decision, every result
- Examiners want to see that you understand, not just that you built
- Attendance is mandatory — non-attendance = automatic NS grade

*Good luck — this is your moment to shine.*